Gies program health

Enrollment, Big Ten peers, course grades, and scheduling at the Gies College of Business, from public data. Om Vyas, October 25, 2026.

An independent analysis built only from public data, not affiliated with or endorsed by the University of Illinois. Code and data: github.com/omvyas77/program-health.

Summary

Gies grew from 5,155 students in Fall 2017 to 10,095 in Fall 2026, and online graduate programs account for 4,781 of the 4,940 added; undergraduate headcount has since risen 15.4% in five years. Illinois ranks 7th of 18 Big Ten schools in first-year retention but 14th in the share of its bachelor's degrees awarded in business. In Gies undergraduate courses, 80.0% of grades were in the A range in Fall 2025, and most of the rise since Fall 2015 happened within the same courses, so grades tell an assessment committee where to look, not what students learned. 5 large courses stand out for the share of students at C or below or withdrawing. My projection puts undergraduate headcount at 3,841 by Fall 2030, though in a backtest it only matched a naive forecast.

Online programs carried Gies's growth

Gies enrolled 10,095 students in Fall 2026, up from 5,155 in Fall 2017, and online graduate programs account for 4,781 of the 4,940 students added (Figure 1). The curriculum reports list no Gies program code ending in U, the marker for an online program, before Fall 2017. By Fall 2026, 89.4% of Gies graduate students, 5,763 of 6,443, were in an online program, 3,847 of them in the online MBA.

Growth has since shifted from graduate to undergraduate students. Graduate headcount peaked at 6,666 in Fall 2021 and was 3.3% lower in Fall 2026, while undergraduate headcount rose 15.4%, from 3,165 to 3,652. Fall 2026 brought 901 first-time freshmen; from Fall 2012 to Fall 2023 the entering class ranged from 560 to 673.

Most first- and second-year Gies students are in Business Undeclared, so I measure majors by juniors and seniors. Accountancy went from 663 in Fall 2021 to 545 in Fall 2026 and Finance from 555 to 610. The three majors paired with Data Science, new in Fall 2022, had 557.

Illinois among its Big Ten peers

IPEDS reports the whole university, so these comparisons describe Illinois rather than Gies; where DAIR publishes a Gies figure, I give it too.

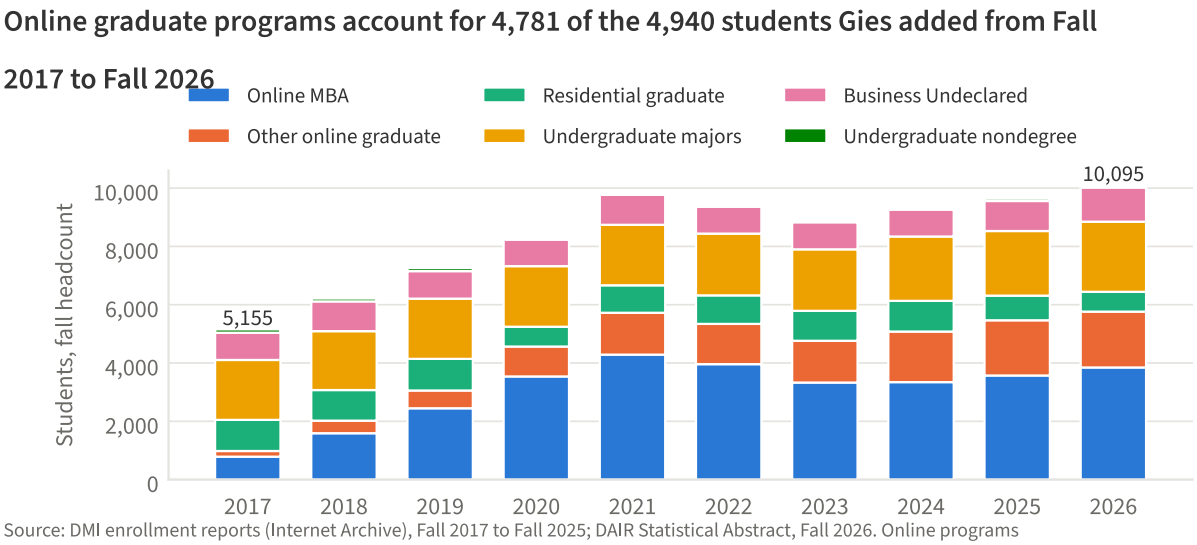


Figure 1: Gies fall headcount by program group.

Illinois retains first-year students well. Of the Fall 2023 cohort returning in fall 2024, 94.8% returned, 7th of the 18 Big Ten schools and above the peer median of 93.0% (Figure 2). Retention rose 1.9 percentage points from the Fall 2018 cohort returning in fall 2019, while the peer median fell 0.6. Six-year graduation for the 2018 cohort was 85.1%, against a peer median of 85.3%. By college of entry, DAIR puts Gies ahead of the campus: 92.0% of Gies's 2018 entrants graduated within six years, against 85.1% campus-wide, and 97.3% of its Fall 2025 freshmen returned, against 94.9%.

Admission has become more selective. Illinois drew 73,742 applicants for its Fall 2024 entering class, up from 43,509 five years earlier, and admitted 42.4%, 16.7 points below the Fall 2019 entering class and below the peer median of 58.1%. Of those admitted, 28.8% enrolled, against a peer median of 22.4%.

Business is a smaller part of Illinois's undergraduate output than at most peers. Business (CIP 52) accounted for 9.5% of the bachelor's degrees Illinois awarded from July 2024 to June 2025, 14th of 18 against a peer median of 16.7%. At the master's level the order reverses: Illinois awarded 2,488 business master's degrees, the most in the Big Ten and 4.4 times the peer median. One gap stands out: in the 2018 cohort, Pell recipients graduated within six years at a rate 10.9 points below other students, a wider gap than the peer median of 6.3.

What course grades can and can't tell an assessment committee

Grades in Gies undergraduate courses have risen faster than grades across campus. In Fall 2010, 54.4% of grades in Gies undergraduate courses were in the A range and the mean GPA was 3.38; in Fall 2025 the figures were 80.0% and 3.72, across 13,070 graded students. Campus-wide, the A-range share went from 48.6% to 69.8% and the GPA from 3.21 to 3.52 (Figure 3, left). Leaving out the covid terms, when students could take courses credit/no credit, a straight line through the fall terms climbs 1.9 percentage points a year for Gies and 1.6 for the campus.

The rise happened inside courses, not through a shift in which courses students took. From Fall 2015 to Fall 2025 the A-range share rose 21.7 points. In the 48 courses taught in both terms, 17.5 points came from higher shares within the same courses, 0.5 from enrollment moving toward courses that already graded higher, and 1.6 from the two together; courses added or dropped account for the other 2.2 (Figure 3, right).

Grades describe grading, not learning. A rising share of A grades can reflect better-prepared students, changes in how courses assess, or changes in how they grade, and these data can't tell those apart. What they can do is show a committee where direct evidence would be worth collecting.

Failing and withdrawing are rare (1.4% of grades in Gies undergraduate courses in Fall 2025 were D, F, or W), so the share at C or below or withdrawing says more. In 5 courses with 150 or more graded

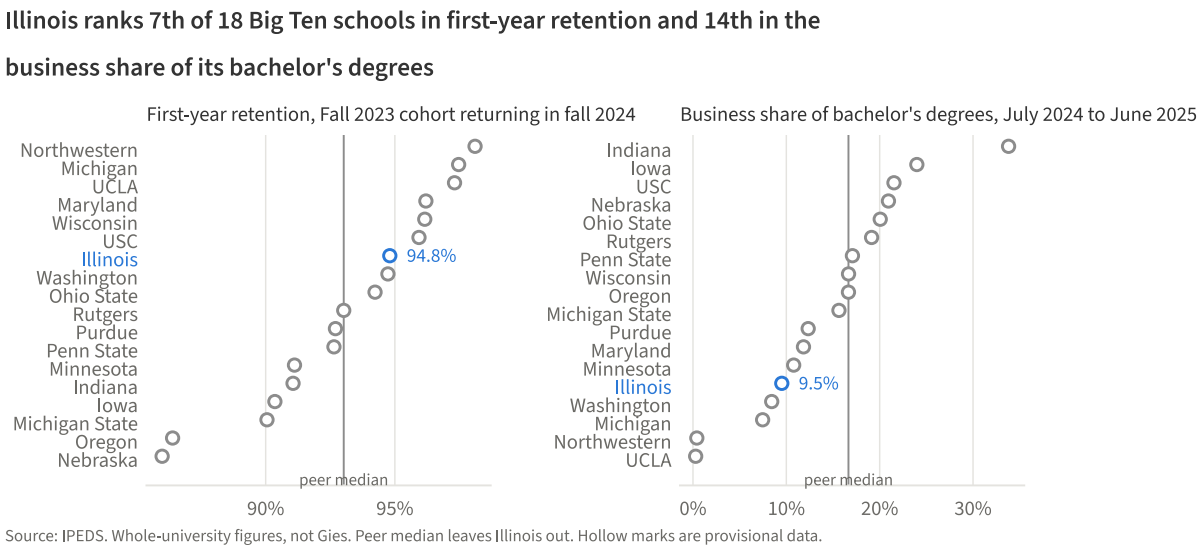


Figure 2: Illinois among the 18 Big Ten schools, latest year.

students a term, 15% or more of students were at C or below or withdrew in at least 2 of the last four long terms: ACCY 201, ACCY 202, ACCY 301, ACCY 303, and FIN 300 (23.3% over four terms in FIN 300). Each is a question for its department about preparation, placement, and support, not a verdict on its teaching.

Sections of one course differ too: in the last four long terms, section GPAs within a Gies undergraduate course were up to 1.04 points apart. That shows where common assessments or rubrics could be compared, not which section graded correctly.

AACSB's 2026 Global Standards take effect in 2027-28, after a 2026-27 pilot year with about 30 schools, and continuous improvement reviews with visits from 2027-28 on use them [8]. Standard 5 asks for direct and indirect measures of learning tied to stated competencies; grade distributions are neither, but they show where to apply such measures first. The watch list belongs under Standard 6, learner progression, and section spread is a place for Standard 7's review of teaching effectiveness to start.

Where scheduling is tight

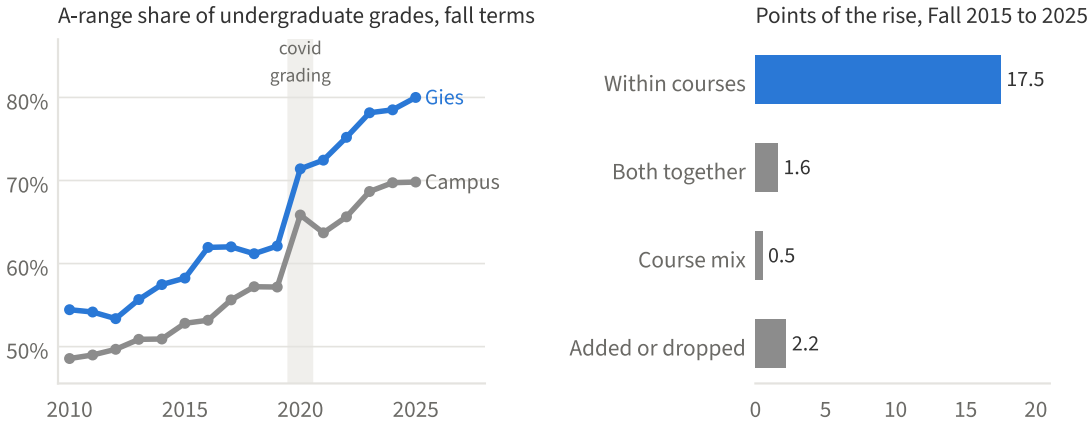
Gies offered 518 primary sections, lectures and seminars rather than discussions or labs, in Fall 2025, against 480 in Fall 2019, while graded students rose from 21,795 to 30,067. Graded students per primary section went from 55.9 to 69.8. That runs a little low, because the GPA data leave out sections of 20 or fewer graded students; I don't use the GPA data's own section count, because grades moved from discussion sections to lectures over these years. 5 courses ran fewer primary sections in Fall 2025 than in Fall 2019 while their graded students rose: ACCY 500, ACCY 505, BADM 509, BADM 572, and FIN 321.

A scheduled job reads the Spring 2027 schedule from Course Explorer every day. As of Oct 25, 2026, registration opens in 8 days, on Nov 2, 2026, and Gies listed 509 primary sections in 225 courses. The public schedule shows sections added and removed but has no seat counts, caps, waitlists, or open and closed status. The usual scheduling measure, average enrollment over average enrollment cap, needs exactly what is missing, so a section added during registration is a hint of demand and nothing more.

Outlook

I project Gies undergraduate headcount as a stock and flow: next fall's undergraduates are the first-time freshmen and new transfers who arrive plus the share of this fall's undergraduates who continue. The base scenario holds freshmen at 783 and transfers at 83 a year, their mean over Falls 2024 to 2026, and the continuing share at 78.1%, the median of the last five fall-to-fall transitions outside covid. It reaches 3,841 undergraduates by Fall 2030, with low and high scenarios of 3,632 and 4,171 (Figure 4).

80.0% of grades in Gies undergraduate courses were in the A range in Fall 2025, against 69.8% campus-wide; 17.5 of the 21.7-point rise since Fall 2015 happened inside the same courses



Source: UIUC GPA dataset (wadefagen/datasets), sections with 21 or more graded students. A range is A+, A, and A-. The split uses the 48 Gies courses taught in both terms, weighted by graded students.

Figure 3: Grades in undergraduate courses.

In a backtest from Fall 2016 on, the model's mean absolute percentage error was 2.8% one year ahead and 4.2% four years ahead, against 2.9% and 4.7% for simply carrying the last fall forward. That margin is too small to call a win: the model matches the naive forecast rather than beating it. Most of its error comes from guessing intake. Given the freshmen and transfers who actually arrived, the one-year error falls to 1.5%.

So the levers are intake and continuation. Each 50 more freshmen a year adds 143 undergraduates by Fall 2030, and each percentage point of continuing share adds 109. If freshmen held at Fall 2026's 901, the base would reach 4,180.

Online graduate headcount is projected flat at 5,763, with an 80% range of 3,682 to 7,844 by Fall 2030; a damped trend, which carried the programs' early growth forward, lost to the naive forecast at every horizon.

WICHE projects Illinois's public and private high school graduates to fall from 144,561 in the class of 2025 to 119,005 in 2035, 17.7% fewer [7]. A what-if on that decline, the in-state admit rate that would keep in-state enrollment flat, waits on verified Common Data Set figures for Illinois.

What an internal version would add

Public data stop where the questions get specific. Student records would give retention and graduation by program and major, including the online programs, rather than by college of entry. Course evaluation results would add the evidence about teaching that Standard 7 asks for and grades can't supply. The admissions system would give Gies's own funnel, which IPEDS reports only for the university. The scheduling system would give caps and waitlists, turning the registration watch into fill ratios. And the assurance-of-learning results Gies already collects could be read against the grade patterns here.

Methods and sources

Every number in this brief is computed from the project's data marts by code in the repository; the analysis tables behind it are in docs/findings.md, and the projection's equations and backtest in docs/projection_method.md. Peer medians are the median of the 17 Big Ten schools other than Illinois. Penn State is missing from its 2019 to 2021 IPEDS collections, when it reported all campuses together.

1. NCES, Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System, complete data files.
2. UIUC Division of Management Information, enrollment reports, Fall 2012 to Fall 2025, via the Internet Archive.
3. UIUC Data, Analytics, and Institutional Research, Statistical Abstract; Retention and Graduation Rates.
4. W. Fagen-Ulmschneider, UIUC GPA dataset and course catalog, github.com/wadefagen/datasets.
5. UIUC Course Explorer API, daily Spring 2027 snapshots.
6. Common Data Sets of the Big Ten universities, 2024-25 and 2025-26.
7. WICHE, Knocking at the College Door, 11th edition, 2024.
8. AACSB, Global Standards for Business Education, 2026, aacsb.edu/educators/global-standards.

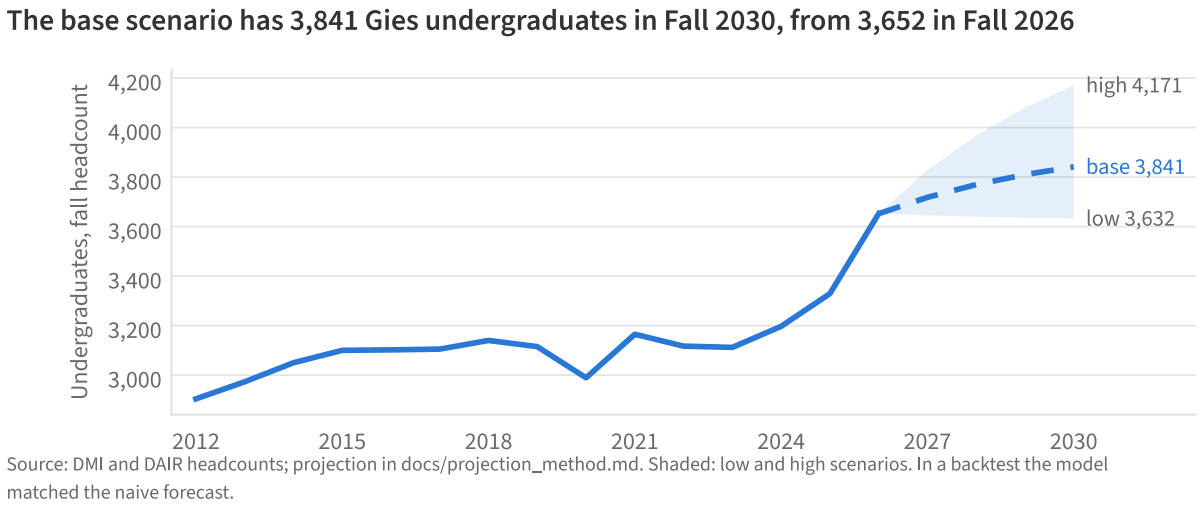


Figure 4: Gies undergraduate headcount, actual and projected.